r/Fencing • 1d ago
u/miss_cara

Fencing Etiquette

Hi! I am about to compete for the first time ever (in the US) and I am anxious about social rules and etiquette both on and off the strip. Any advice or dos/don'ts for a socially anxious first-timer?

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BanditKitten • 4h ago • Edited 3h ago
Épée

Everything u/BeyoncePadThai23 said is excellent advice. I'd add:

Bring your water with you to the strip!!!

Test all your gear when you warm up, prior to reporting to your strip. If you're there alone... make a friend to warm up with. Or ask a pair of people on a strip if you can direct for them and also hop in to test and do a little bouting as a group.

You must also show your director your plastron when you check in.

Try to do some bout analysis when you're not up. Look at what actions the other fencers are using. Maybe someone is consistently using an action that you're actually very comfortable responding to! Then you'll have a bit of a strategy going into your bout with them. Don't psych yourself out, though. Your first tournament is going to have hiccups, so don't start spiraling when something eventually goes wrong. Other things will go right, and all the experience is valuable regardless.

After your bout/poule is over, you could (if there's time) ask the director any additional questions you might have. If you thought you were taking a parry and they called it against you, ask what you could do to be more clear! Also, CHECK YOUR SCORE SHEET. Ask your coach now how to read one. It's not awful. Just keep checking that sheet and communicate clearly with your director. Once you sign the score sheet, THAT'S PERMANENT. Scores cannot be changed once they've been entered in the software the event uses.

Finally, say thank you to the director! Then scurry off into a corner and lick your wounds before the Direct Elimination portion starts.

2 Reply

BeyoncePadThai23 • 1d ago

tournament, and they should help guide you.

Important stuff: make sure you have a backup body cord and weapon near the strip you're fencing at.

When the referee is checking everyone in for the pool, be ready with your mask, glove and body cord to check for armory marks and tags. Listen for what your number is in the pool, and listen for it to be called. First number called is the fencer on the right, except when there's a lefty, they are usually on the left.

Salute your opponent and the referee, some referees are particular and want you to salute the spectators, but that's not everyone.

After the bout, return to the end garde line, remove your mask and salute everyone you saluted at the beginning of the bout. Approach your opponent, and tap blades and/or shake hands, whatever they feel comfortable with. You can say, "good bout," if you like.

Make sure you take all your stuff (including any weapons that have failed weight or shim) and return back to the sidelines and wait for the next bout.

If a tournament is using Fencing Time live, you can follow the bout order on your phone.

Good luck and have fun!

18 Reply ···

miss_cara OP • 1d ago

Thank you! This is helpful

3 Reply ···

Managed-Chaos-8912 • 1d ago

Épée

Follow the fencing rules on strip. You can talk to whomever you want off strip. If your coach is coming with you, listen to them. You can also ask fencers for advice after fencing them. Or just talk to them for social practice. I have friends that are members of other clubs. We have tremendous rivalry on strip, and are friends off strip. YOU HAVE NO FRIENDS ON STRIP! That shows up in doing your best while fencing, not attitude.

24 Reply ···

Arbiter_89 • 1d ago

Épée

Do the same things you do at your club (Salute, handshake, etc)

Make sure you read the score card CAREFULLY before you sign it.

Make sure you check in right away and verify your name is on the list they post initially before they announce pools. If your name was missed, bring it up IMMEDIATELY. If you try to fix it after pools are announced you're out of luck.

8 Reply ···

p0rkch0pexpress • 1d ago • Edited 1d ago

Foil

Depending on where you are in the US. 3 point salute (crowd ref each other).

Be ready for an equipment check (half unzip your lame/ jacket or both)

Make sure you know the tournament rules for who and what you can do on the strip. We have a tournament here once a year that has no strip coaching and VERY tight rules about who can and can't be in the pod of strips.

Make sure you bought or your club gave you the appropriate handed gear (right handed/left handed/ back zip) and someone I know got carded for the wrong direction of the pants (left handed pants and right handed pants) that was in CA but we are cracking down on that this season in the Northeast US.

Edit: some tournaments have strict rules at who can look at score sheets posted. We have 1 the same I mentioned above that only coaches can approach the scoring/bout committee area unless otherwise specified. They haven't since I've been there but the result for breaking this is a black card at this tournament.

4 Reply ···

miss_cara OP • 1d ago

This is helpful! Idk how or why pants are "right handed" but I know I have the correct pants. Do people show up fully suited for equipment checks prior to their event?

3 Reply ···

p0rkch0pexpress • 1d ago

Foil

We had a like 60 team meeting (you can probably guess what tournament) about it. It's the flap on thr crotch and the pocket is the dead giveaway. I believe it's Rh right pocket and LH left pocket

2 Reply ···

sjcfu2 • 1d ago

Top 1% Commenter

There may be different types of equipment checks, depending on the size of the tournament.

In smaller tournaments where the referees are probably the only ones checking, they will often have all of the fencers in their pool gather together prior to the first bout in order to verify that everyone is wearing proper safety gear (including underarm protectors -this is when it helps to have your jacket open). Then prior to each bout there will be the standard weapons checks (weight and shim, depending on the weapon, plus also making sure that everything is plugged in properly and that nothing is present which shouldn't be there).

At larger tournaments a separate equipment check may be performed by the armorers prior to the start of the event. Typically these inspections look at the masks (both for safety and conductivity),

inspection will generally be marked, either with a stamp or colored tape, and referees will be looking for these inspection marks when you report to their strip.

2 Reply ···



CatLord8 • 1d ago

Foil Coach Top 1% Commenter

When I can see the eyes glaze over with students as I speedrun the penalty cards, I say the key things are “stay on the strip, don’t turn around, don’t actively be a jerk and you’ll be fine”.

As others have said - you can basically talk to anyone who isn’t in an active bout. Some people may be a bit distracted/aloof and that’s not a reflection on you. Have the bare necessities strip side and keep the bulk of your bag out of the way. Otherwise do what comes natural and you’ll be fine. If it’s your first tourney I actually recommend asking people if they have notes between bouts. It’s a great way to start networking.

3 Reply ···



ZebraFencer • 1d ago

Epee Referee

Use your non-gloved hand for handshakes, left-handers will reach over as necessary (we have practice at that). High-fives are customary for NCAA women. All the other comments in the thread are great.

For check-in at the start of the pool, have your jacket unzipped just enough that you can fold down the collar for the plastron to be visible. Then knock on your hard chest protector with your knuckles so we know it's there. Hang your spare cords on your spare weapon and bring them with you. When the referee checks, hold up your mask and glove with the inspection marks right together to look like an experienced competitor.

Make sure you know your number in the pool and know the bout order. It is OK to ask the referee to take a picture of the pool sheet so you have it on your phone if the bout order isn't up on Fencing Time Live. As previously mentioned, know which side you will be on in the upcoming bout. Then start getting ready a touch or two before the preceding bout ends. When the previous fencers salute and start returning to their ends, be there to take the reel connector from the preceding fencer. Then when you finish, walk back to the reel and hand the connector to the next fencer instead of letting it run back into the reel where she has to bend over to pick it up.

Fence well!

5 Reply ···



Pristine-Pirate-2386 • 1d ago

Make sure your coach has taught you all the thing about saluting, handshakes, etc. Some refs don’t care and some won’t let you fence until you do it properly. Just standard sportsmanship.

Find somewhere appropriate for your bag and don’t fling it across the floor next to the strip where people need to walk. Don’t cut in line at equipment check (seems obvious and yet).

Good luck and have fun!

10 Reply ···

AppBreezy • 1d ago

Foil

1. This is part of the rules, but make sure to salute before and after the bout, and shake hands/highfive after
2. This is more for the ref, but remember your number for your pool, so if the ref is calling out numbers you are ready to go. Better yet, if the event is using fencing time live, have that open on your phone so you can keep track of where you are in the bout order, and know when you're on deck, your ref will appreciate you.
3. Make sure you're not hitting/poking too hard when you're testing your weapon with the other fencer. I'm thinking more of specifically for foil - only poke hard enough to depress the tip and aim low on their lame, don't test too close to their face.
4. Overall just look around you and follow others lead. If you have a teammate with you, ask them. Oh and, don't be afraid to ask questions. There's a handful of etiquette things built into the rules, but ideally your coach or other folks at your club should have taught you those already.

3 Reply ···

RoguePoster • 1d ago

> This is part of the rules, but make sure to salute before and after the bout, and shake hands/highfive after

Shaking hands is no longer part of the rules - hasn't been for years.

3 Reply ···

miss_cara OP • 1d ago

Thank you! I think I'm extra anxious because I'm the only person from my club attending so I'm collecting as much info before I go

2 Reply ···

lalabadmans • 1d ago

Fencing is not a large circle, if you regularly compete, you'll see familiar faces.

Do not stop fencing until halt is called, even if you think you scored. It's common for people inexperienced in competition (or where reffing is not common at the club) to stop and look back at the the box if they think they hit, which is yellow card if no light was on. The ref will call halt if there is a hit or fencing needs to stop.

If foil fencer, check the time near the end of each 1st and 2nd rounds. If the ref calls halt with around 5 seconds left, It's normal etiquette to not rush attack your opponent when he calls allez again. usually just

Xenadon • 1d ago

Don't argue, be polite, and have fun. Make sure you have a backup weapon and body cord at the strip with you. Everything else you can pick up as you go.

1 Reply ···

BronzeEnt • 1d ago

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